

## ON TECHNIQUE

### Chopin's pianos

For most of his career, Chopin used pianos by the two leading French manufacturers, Erard and Pleyel. Erard pianos produced a bigger, richer sound, but Chopin generally preferred the bright, silvery tone of Pleyels: “When I am not in the mood, I play on the Erard piano, where I find the ready tone easily. But when I am full of vigor and strong enough to find my very own tone, I need a Pleyel.” During his stay in Britain he also enjoyed using the “very sweet instruments” produced by the firm of Broadwood.



CHOPIN'S PLEYEL PIANO IN HIS APARTMENT IN PARIS

No composer is more intimately associated with the piano than Chopin. All his compositions involve the instrument, on which he was a superlative performer. They are mainly solo pieces, although he also wrote orchestral works (notably two sparkling piano concertos), some chamber music, and a few songs. His work is deeply personal and full of heartfelt emotion, but there is never any of the exhibitionism sometimes associated with Romanticism. Instead, it displays exquisite taste and craftsmanship—an expression of his own fastidious